

Lecture 20 (Data Structures 5)

Priority Queues and Heaps

CS61B, Spring 2026 @ UC Berkeley

Josh Hug and Kay Ousterhout



Let's first wrap up our discussion of search trees:

https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1xq_D_4tWIAHULDMXPBmrmvk2gy5qgtmoG1JCwhXcPo/edit?slide=id.g213d1cb6cd3_0_510#slide=id.g213d1cb6cd3_0_510

Note: BST Homework is out.

- Due Friday.
- There will also be an RRR week homework where you can implement the red black tree (as needed for personal edification / points).

Introducing the Priority Queue

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Priority Queue Introduction

- **Introducing the Priority Queue**
- Using a PQ
- Some Bad Implementations

Heaps

- Heap Definitions
- Heap Add
- Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

Data Structures Summary

```
/** (Min) Priority Queue: Allowing tracking and removal of the  
 * smallest item in a priority queue. */  
public interface MinPQ<Item> {  
    /** Adds the item to the priority queue. */  
    public void add(Item x);  
    /** Returns the smallest item in the priority queue. */  
    public Item getSmallest();  
    /** Removes the smallest item from the priority queue. */  
    public Item removeSmallest();  
    /** Returns the size of the priority queue. */  
    public int size();  
}
```

Useful if you want to keep track of the “smallest”, “largest”, “best” etc. seen so far.

Using a PQ

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Priority Queue Summary

Data Structures Summary

Suppose we have a particle detector that records the energy of incoming particles.

Suppose we want to record the M highest energy particles in a given day.

Naive approach: Create a list of all particles detected during the day. Sort it using a particle energy comparator. Return the M particles that have highest energy.

```
public List<Particle> highestEnergyParticles(Detector det, int M) {  
    ArrayList<Particle> allParticles = new ArrayList<>();  
  
    for (Timer timer = new Timer(); timer.hours() < 24; ) {  
        allParticles.add(det.getNextParticle());  
    }  
  
    Comparator<String> cmptr = new EnergyComparator();  
    Collections.sort(allParticles, cmptr, Collections.reverseOrder());  
  
    return allParticles.sublist(0, M);  
}
```

Potentially uses a huge amount of memory $\Theta(N)$, where N is number of particles.

```
public List<Particle> highestEnergyParticles(Detector det, int M) {  
    ArrayList<Particle> allParticles = new ArrayList<>();  
  
    for (Timer timer = new Timer(); timer.hours() < 24; ) {  
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Potentially uses a huge amount of memory $\Theta(N)$, where N is number of particles.

- Goal: Do this in $\Theta(M)$ memory using a MinPQ.

```
MinPQ<Particle> highEnergyParticles = new HeapMinPQ<>(cmptr);
```



```
public List<Particle> highestEnergyParticles(Detector det, int M) {  
    Comparator<Particle> cmptr = new EnergyComparator();  
    MinPQ<Particle> highEnergyParticles = new HeapMinPQ<>(cmptr);  
    for (Timer timer = new Timer(); timer.hours() < 24; ) {  
        // Do something with det.getNextParticle(); ??  
        ...  
    }  
}
```

Potentially uses a huge amount of memory $\Theta(N)$, where N is number of particles.

- Goal: Do this in $\Theta(M)$ memory using a MinPQ.

```
MinPQ<Particle> highEnergyParticles = new HeapMinPQ<>(cmptr);
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```
public List<Particle> highestEnergyParticles(Detector det, int M) {
    Comparator<Particle> cmptr = new EnergyComparator();
    MinPQ<Particle> highEnergyParticles = new HeapMinPQ<>(cmptr);
    for (Timer timer = new Timer(); timer.hours() < 24; ) {
        highEnergyParticles.add(det.getNextParticle());
        if (highEnergyParticles.size() > M)
            { highEnergyParticles.removeSmallest(); }
    }
    ArrayList<String> returnList = new ArrayList<String>();
    while (highEnergyParticles.size() > 0) {
        returnList.add(highEnergyParticles.removeSmallest());
    }
    return returnList;
}
```

Can track top M transactions using only M memory. API for MinPQ also makes code very simple (don't need to make explicit comparisons).

Some Bad Implementations

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- Heap Delete

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- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

Data Structures Summary

How Would We Implement a MinPQ?

Some possibilities:

- Ordered Array

	Ordered Array
add	$\Theta(N)$
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$
Caveats	

Worst Case $\Theta(\cdot)$ Runtimes

Some possibilities:

- Ordered Array
- Bushy BST

	Ordered Array	Bushy BST
add	$\Theta(N)$	?
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$	?
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$	?
Caveats		

Worst Case $\Theta(\cdot)$ Runtimes



How Would We Implement a MinPQ?

Some possibilities:

- Ordered Array
- Bushy BST: Maintaining bushiness is annoying. **Handling duplicate priorities is awkward.**

	Ordered Array	Bushy BST
add	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$	$\Theta(\log N)$
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$
Caveats		Dups tough

Worst Case $\Theta(\cdot)$ Runtimes

How Would We Implement a MinPQ?

Some possibilities:

- Ordered Array
- Bushy BST: Maintaining bushiness is annoying. **Handling duplicate priorities is awkward.**

	Ordered Array	Bushy BST	Heap
add	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	
Caveats		Dups tough	

Worst Case $\Theta(\cdot)$ Runtimes

How Would We Implement a MinPQ?

Some possibilities:

- Ordered Array
- Bushy BST: Maintaining bushiness is annoying. **Handling duplicate priorities is awkward.**
- HashTable: No good! Items go into random places.

	Ordered Array	Bushy BST	Hash Table	Heap
add	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(1)$	
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(N)$	
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(N)$	
Caveats		Dups tough		

Worst Case $\Theta(\cdot)$ Runtimes

Heap Definitions

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- **Heap Definitions**
 - Heap Add
 - Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

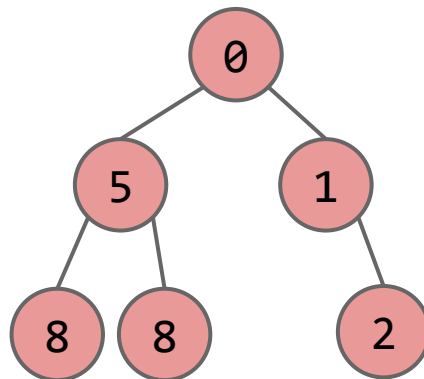
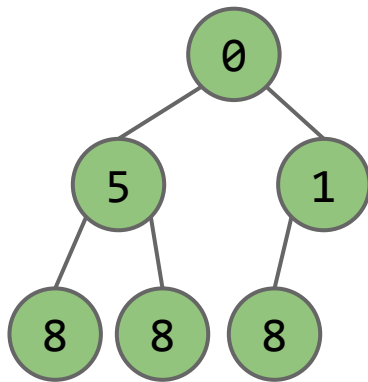
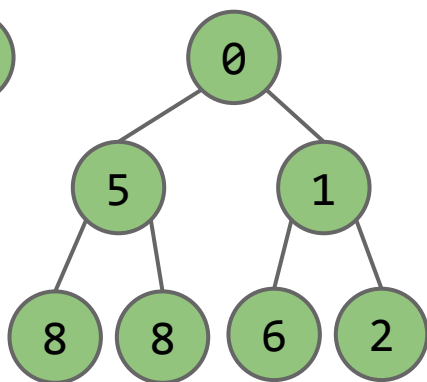
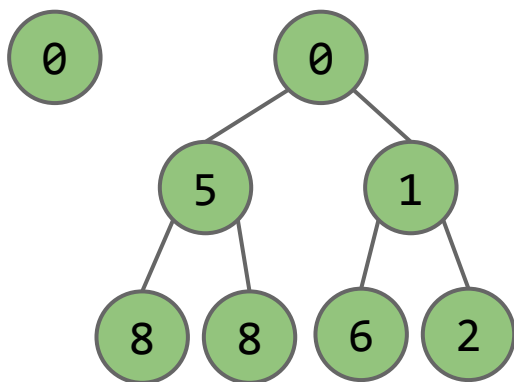
Data Structures Summary

Introducing the Heap

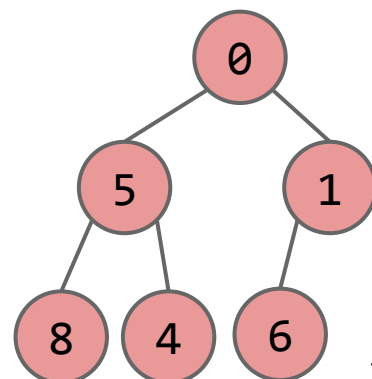
BSTs would work, but need to be kept bushy and duplicates are awkward.

Binary min-heap: Binary tree that is **complete** and obeys **min-heap property**.

- Min-heap: Every node is less than or equal to both of its children.
- Complete: Missing items only at the bottom level (if any), all nodes are as far left as possible.



Incomplete



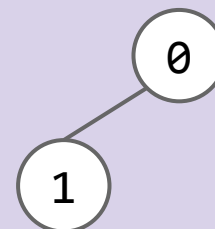
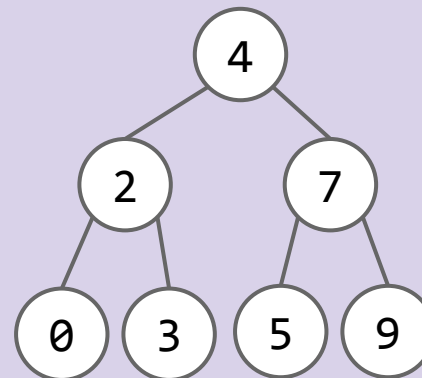
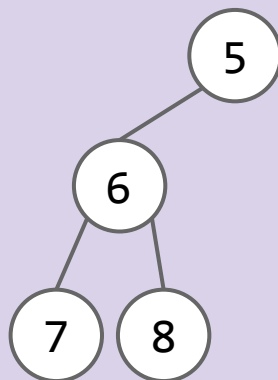
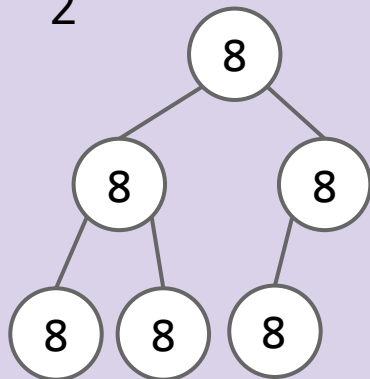
Lacks min-heap property

How many of these are **binary min heaps**

- Min-heap: Every node is less than or equal to both of its children.
- Complete: Missing items only at the bottom level (if any), all nodes are as far left as possible.



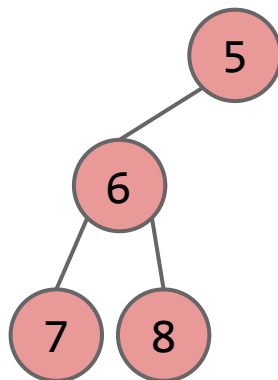
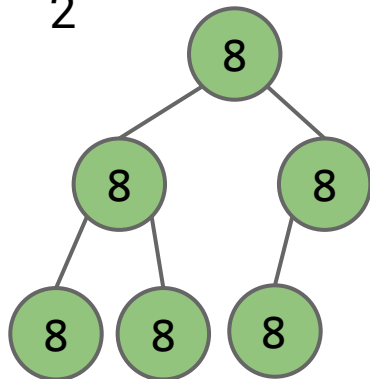
- A. 0 D. 3
B. 1 E. 4
C. 2



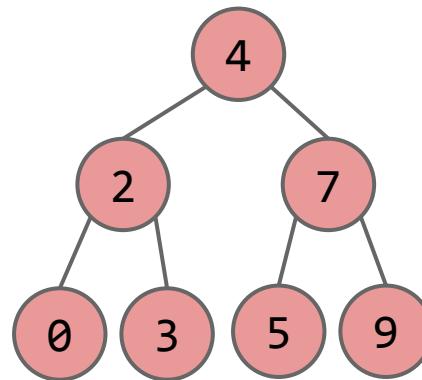
How many of these are **binary min heaps**

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- Complete: Missing items only at the bottom level (if any), all nodes are as far left as possible.

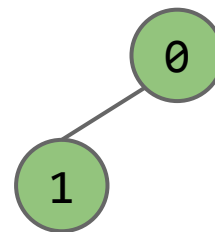
- A. 0 D. 3
B. 1 E. 4
C. 2



Incomplete



Lacks min-heap property

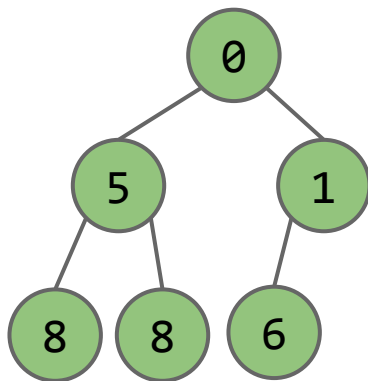


What Good Are Heaps?

Heaps lend themselves very naturally to implementation of a priority queue.

Hopefully easy question:

- How would you support `getSmallest()`?



Heap Add

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Heaps

- Heap Definitions
- **Heap Add**
- Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

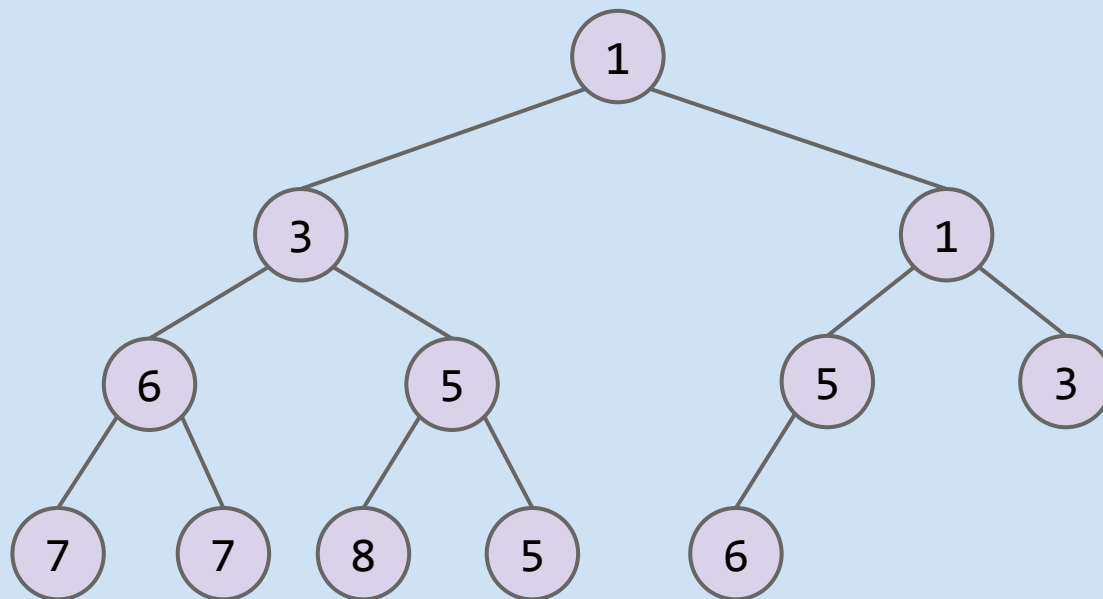
Data Structures Summary

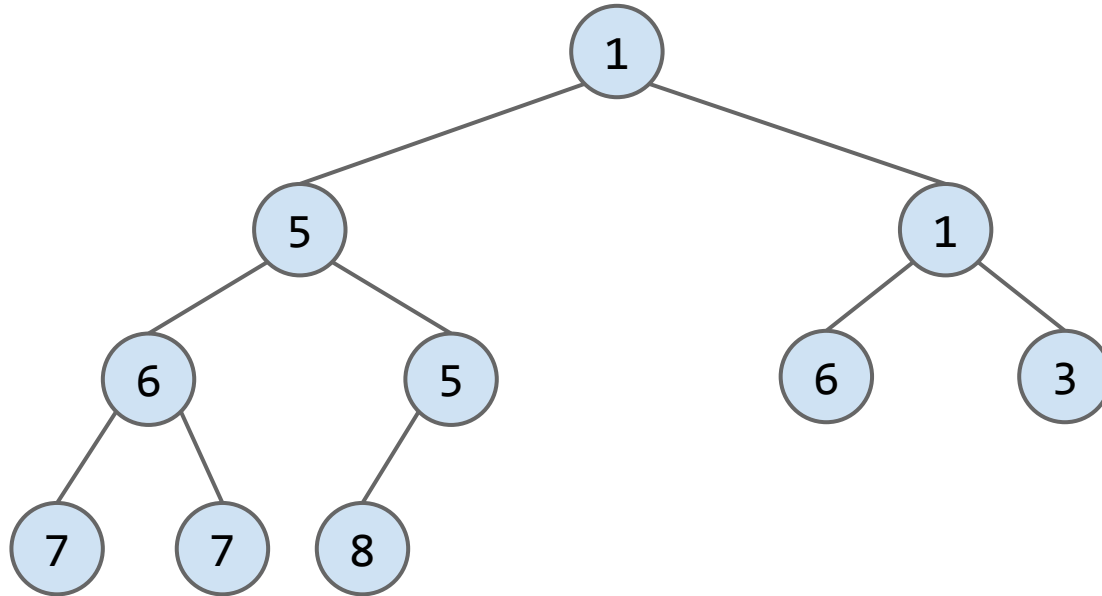
How Do We Add to a Heap?

Challenge: Come up with an algorithm for `add(x)`.

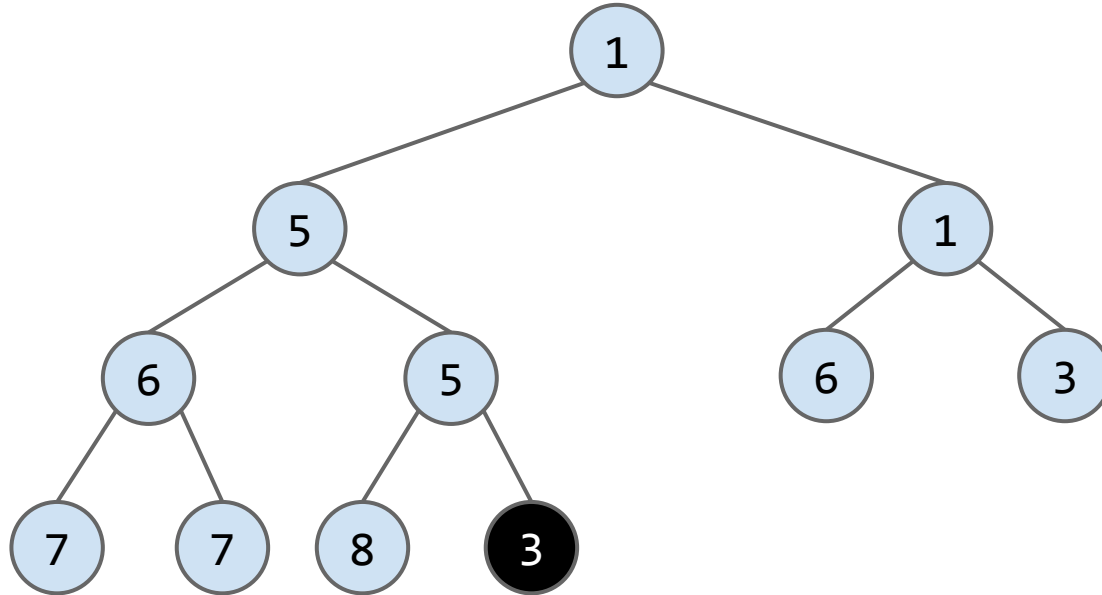
- How would we insert 3?

Runtime must be logarithmic.



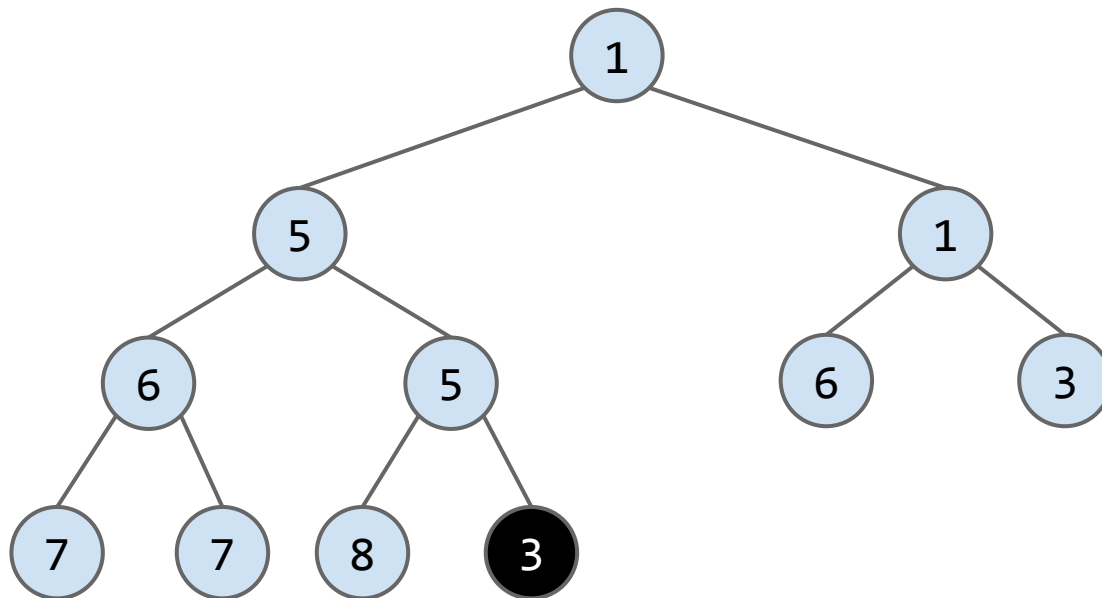


Insert 3?



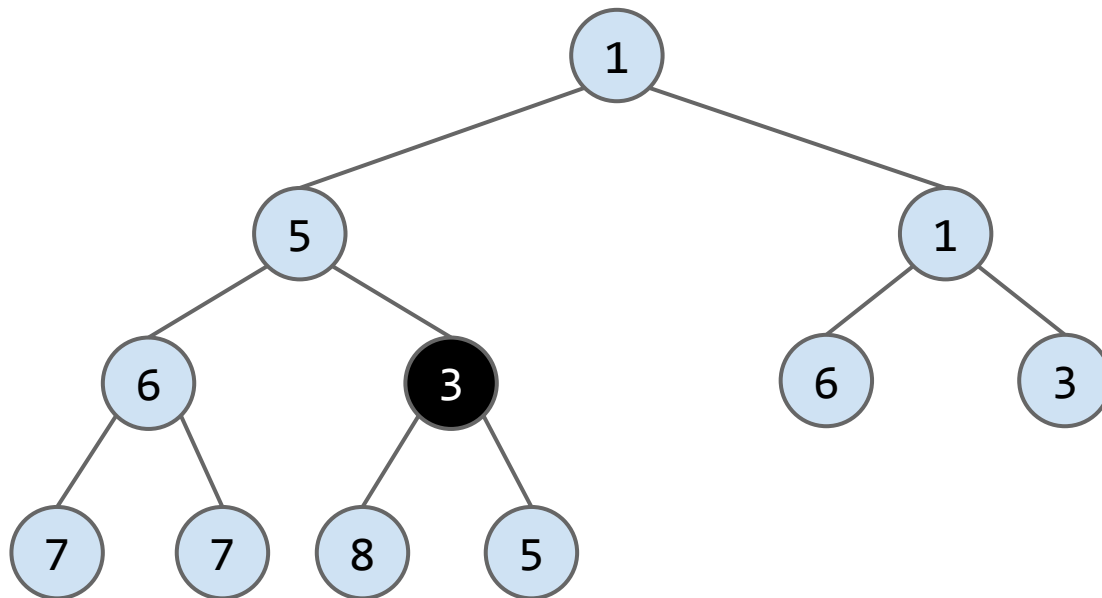
Insert 3.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.



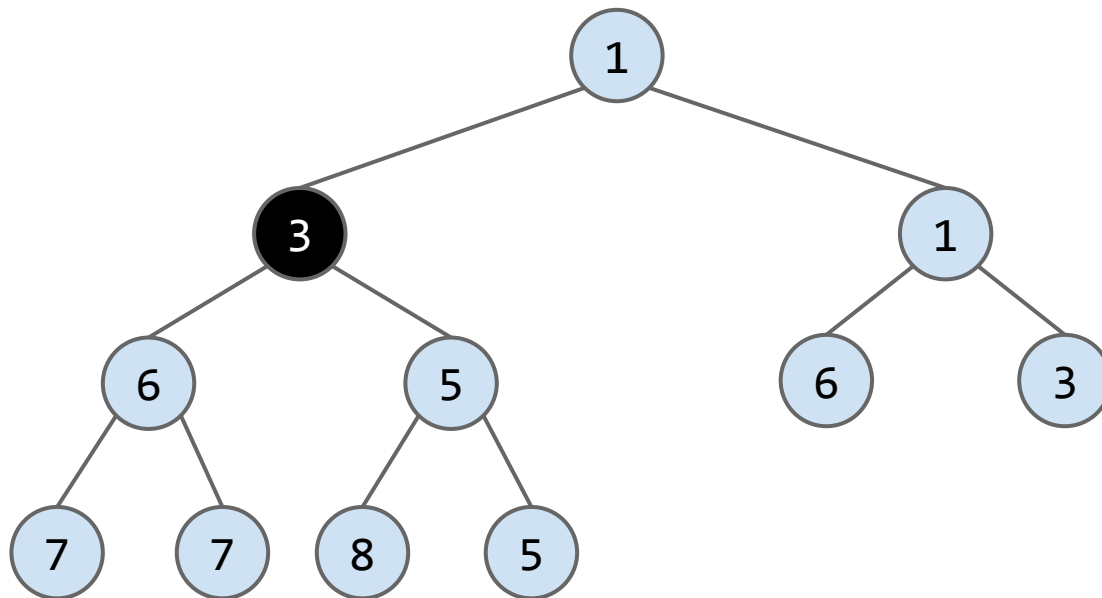
Insert 3.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
- Swim up the hierarchy to your rightful place...



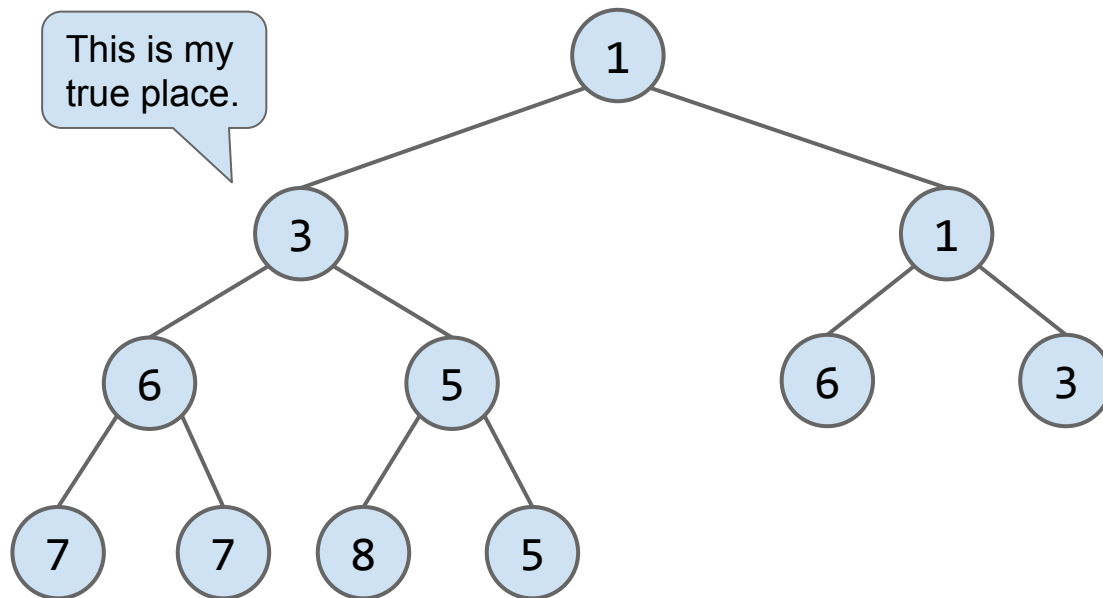
Insert 3.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
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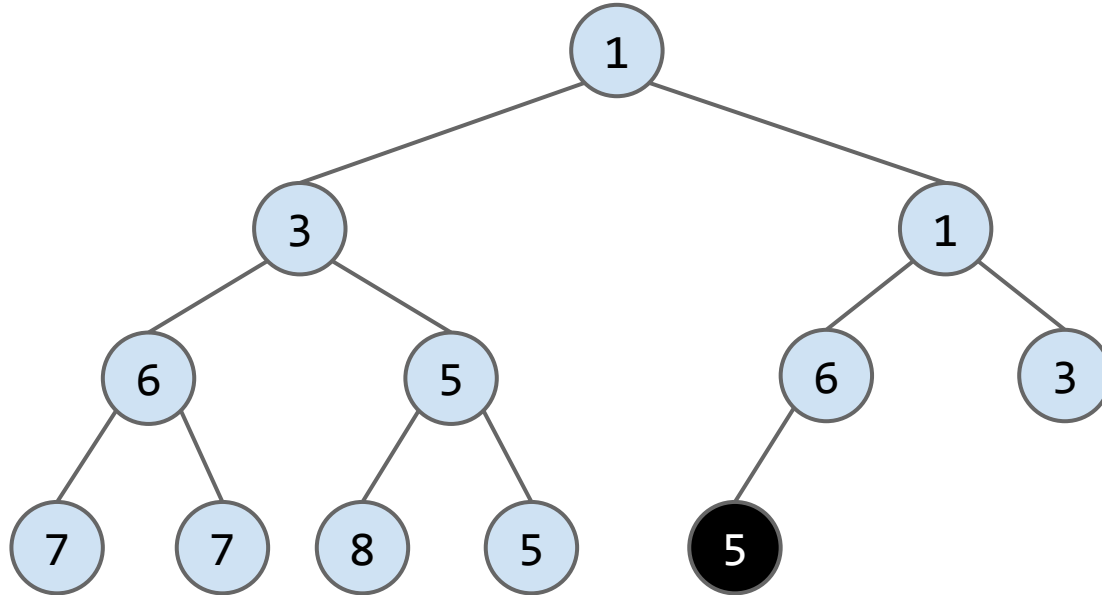
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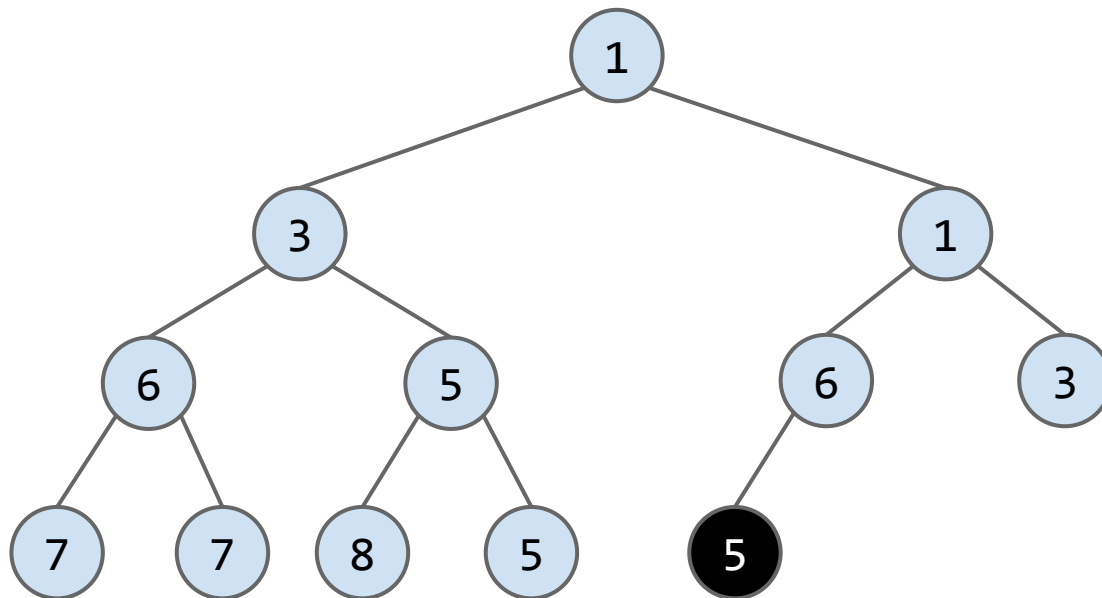
Insert 3.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
- Swim up the hierarchy to your rightful place.



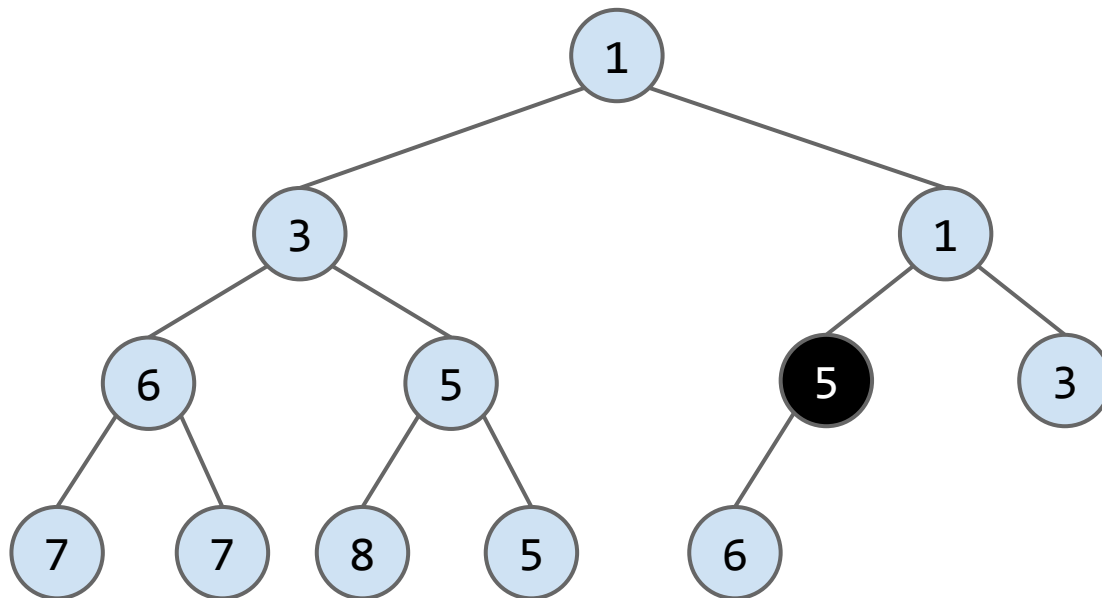
Insert 5.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.



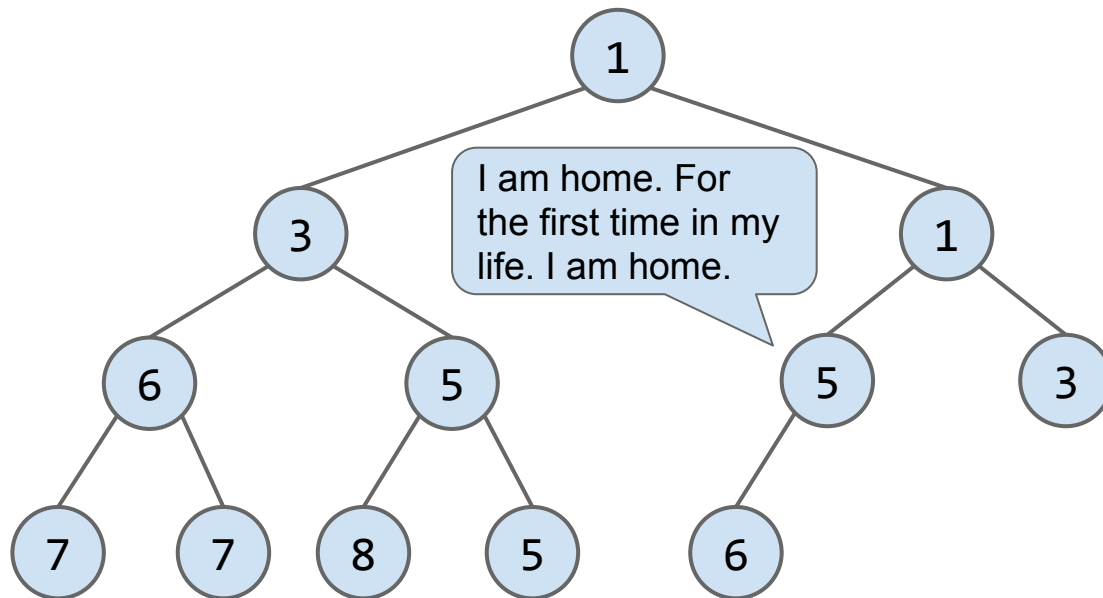
Insert 5.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
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Insert 5.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
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Insert 5.

- Add to end of heap temporarily.
- Swim up the hierarchy to your rightful place.

Heap Delete

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- Heap Add
- **Heap Delete**

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

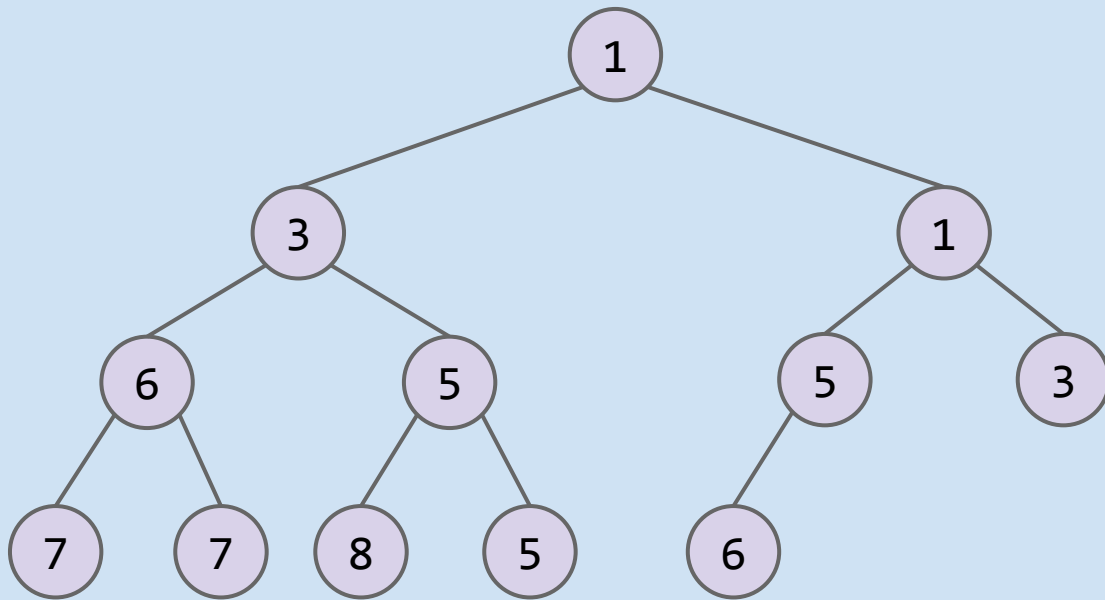
Priority Queue Summary

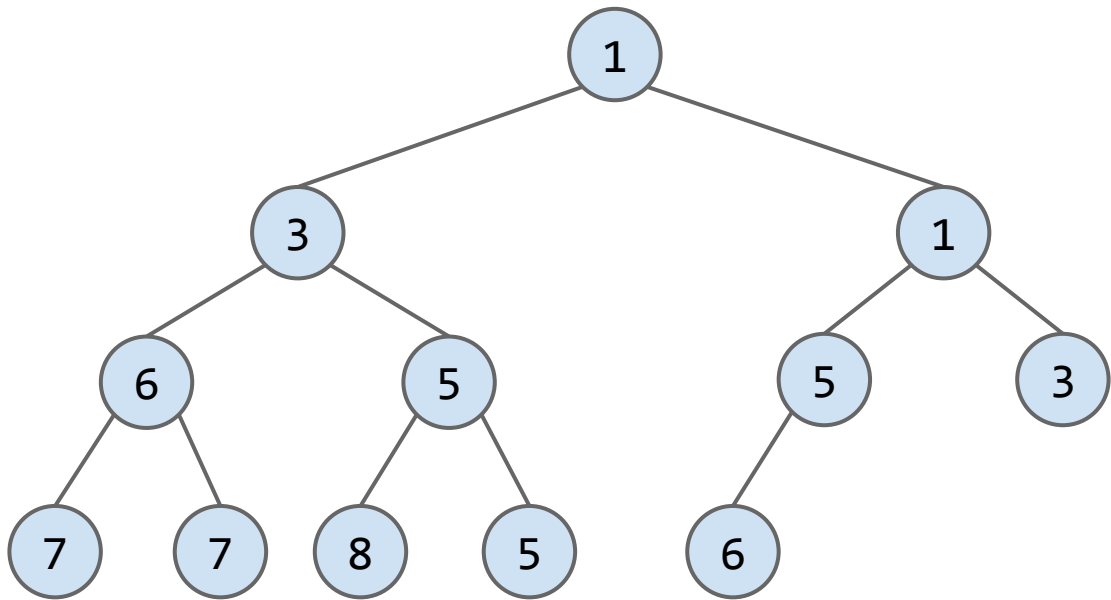
Data Structures Summary

How Do We Remove from a Heap?

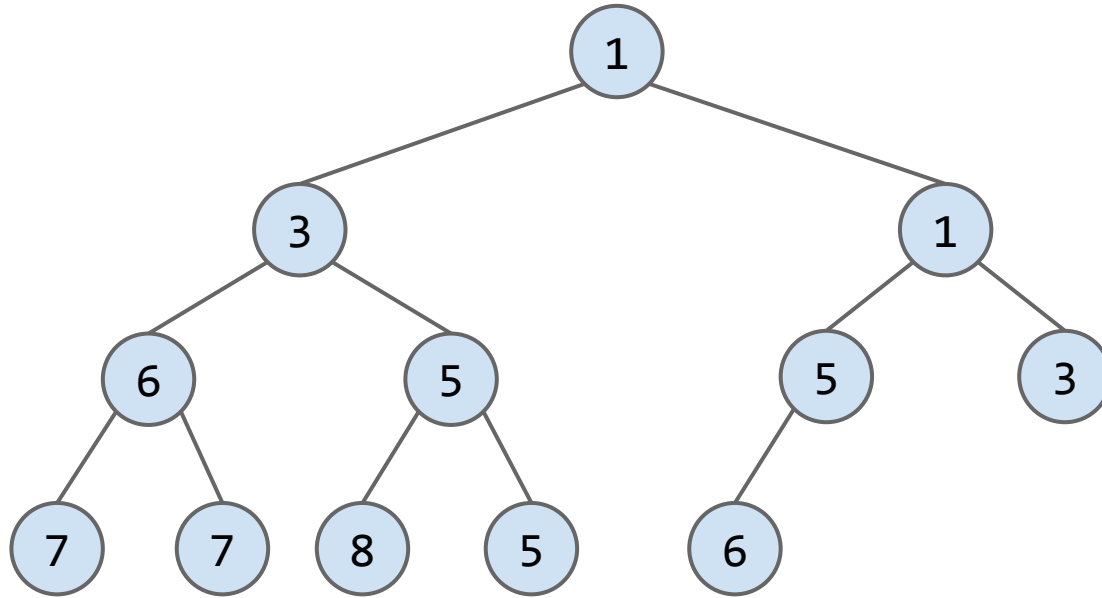
Challenge: Come up with an algorithm for `removeSmallest()`.

Runtime must be logarithmic.





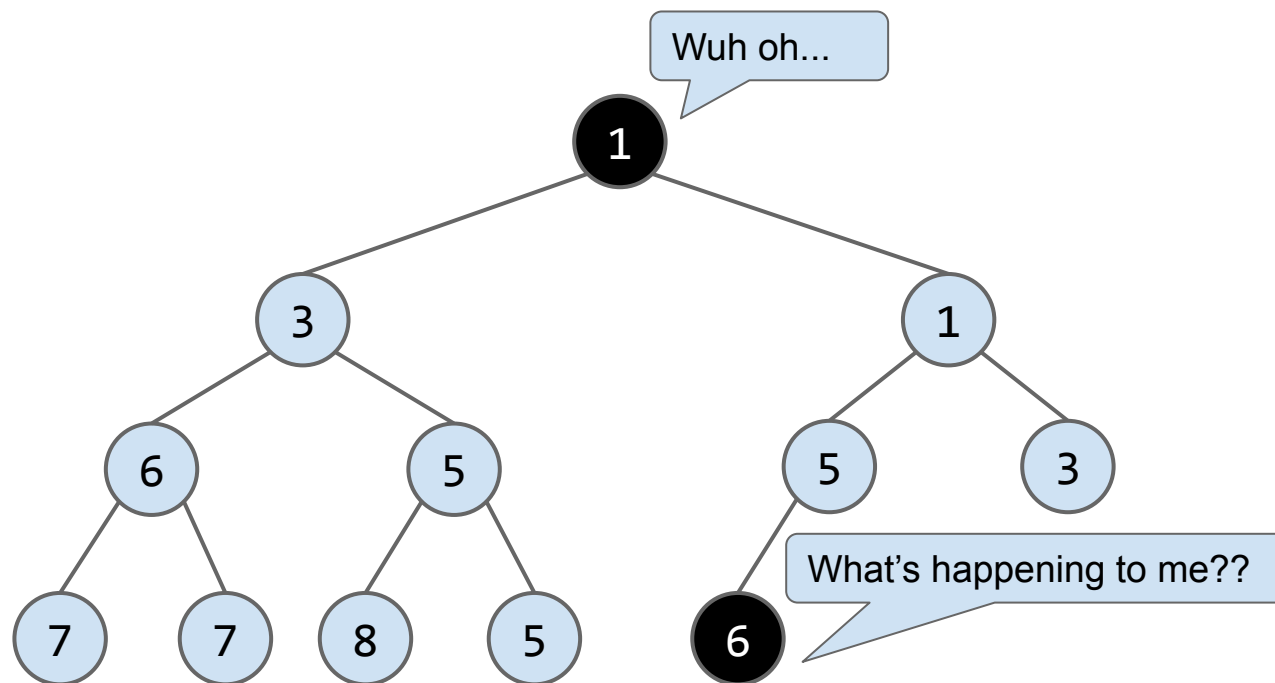
Delete min.



Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.

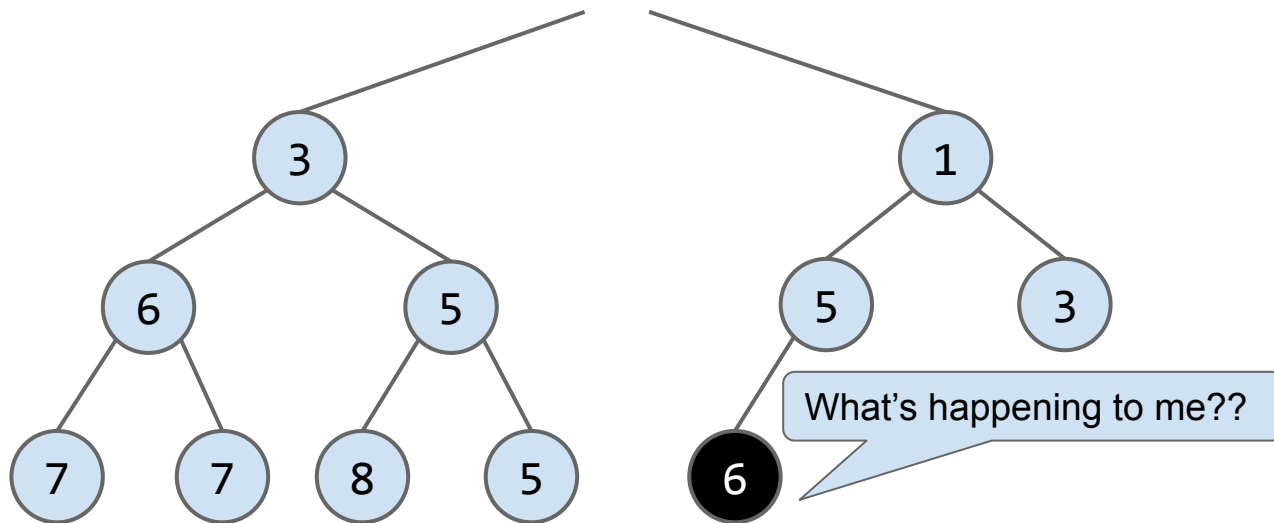
Heap Delete Demo



Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.

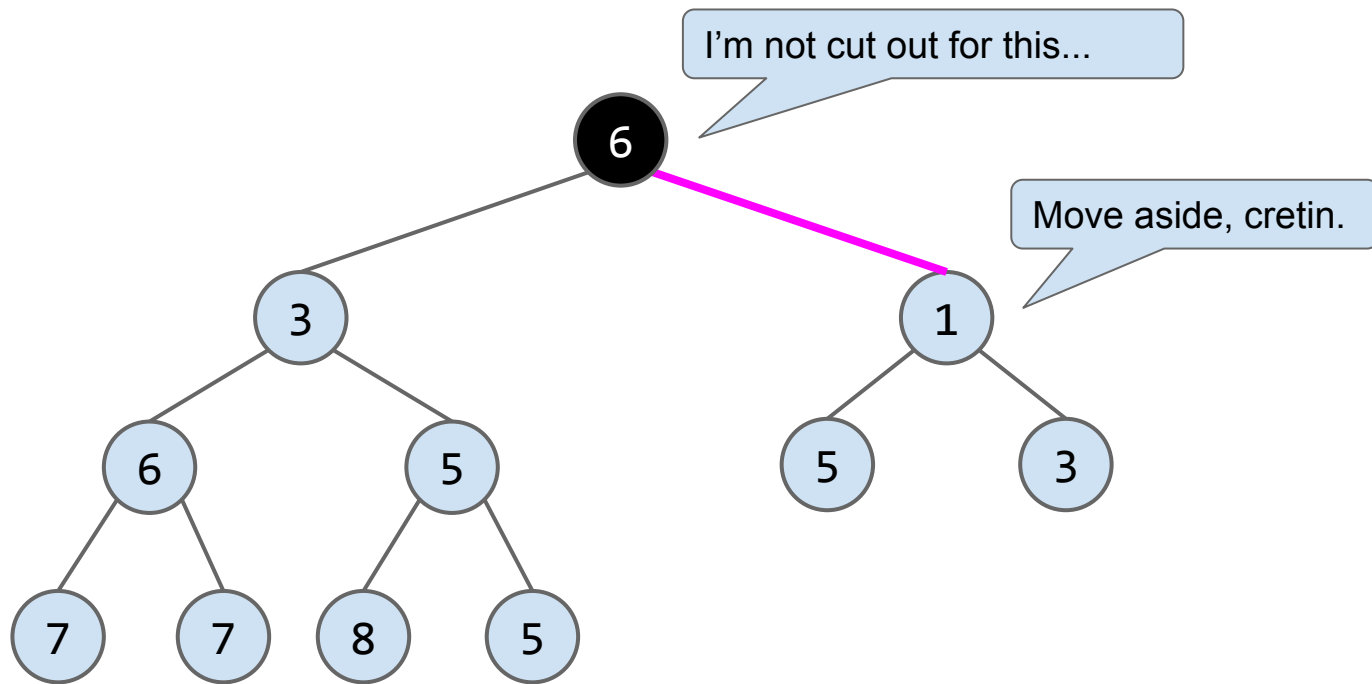
Heap Delete Demo



Delete min.

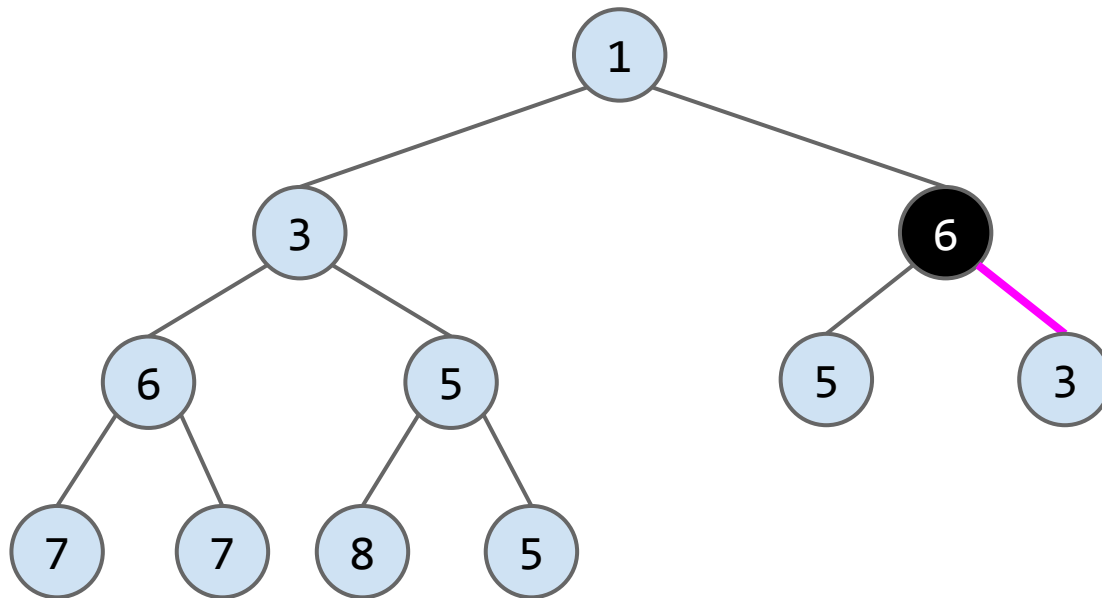
- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.

Heap Delete Demo



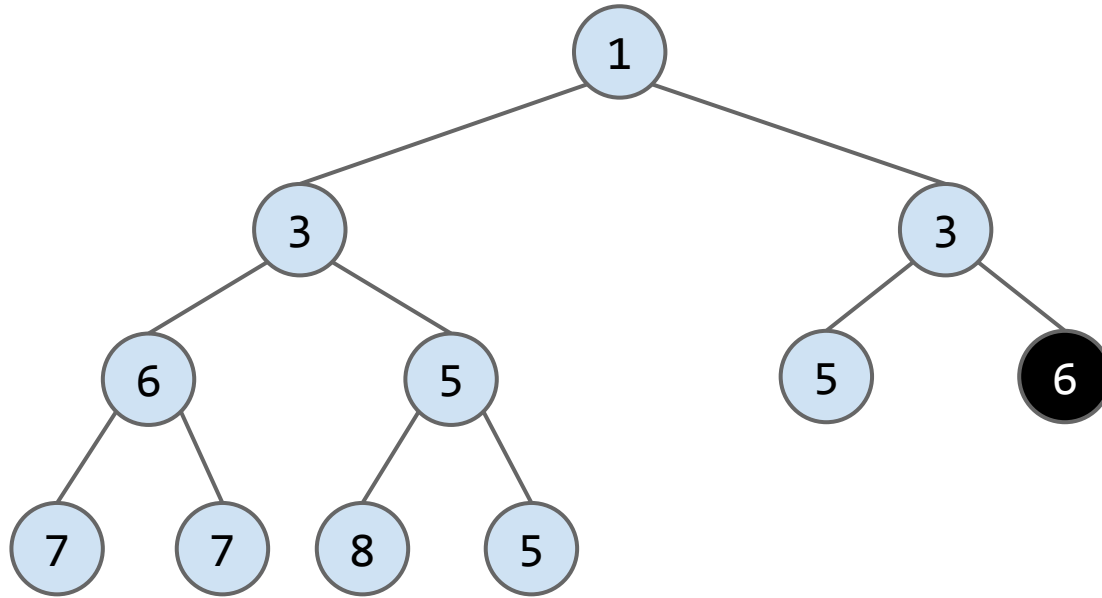
Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.
- Then sink your way down the hierarchy, yielding to most qualified folks...



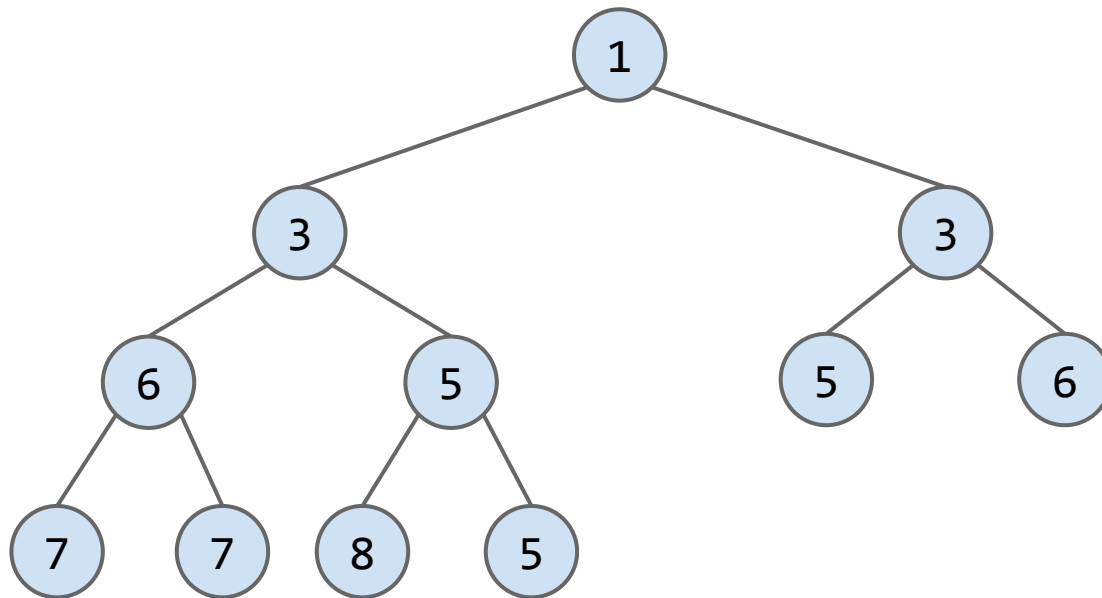
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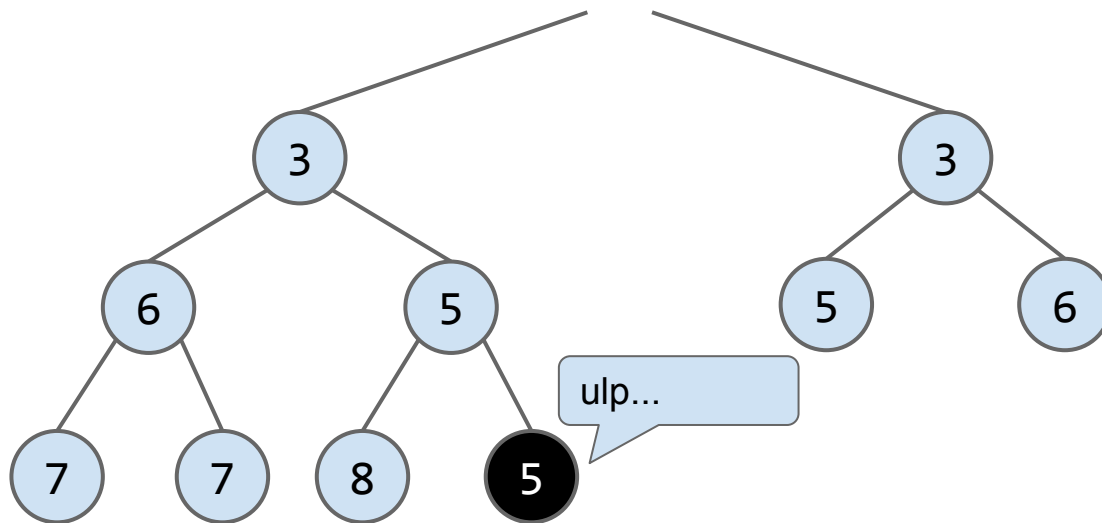
Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.
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Delete min.

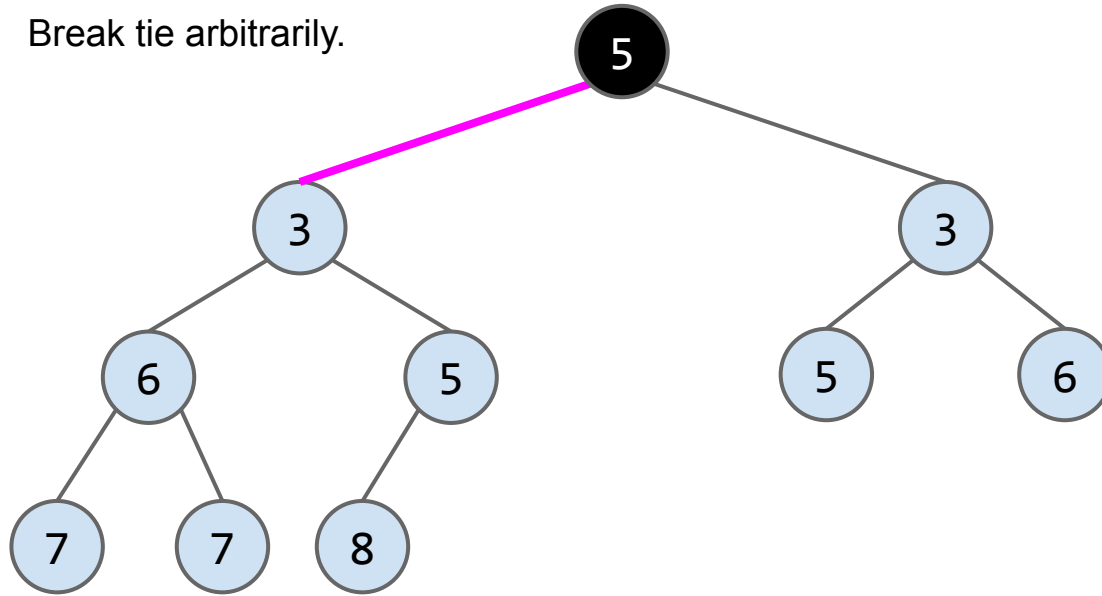
- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.
- Then sink your way down the hierarchy, yielding to most qualified folks.



Delete min.

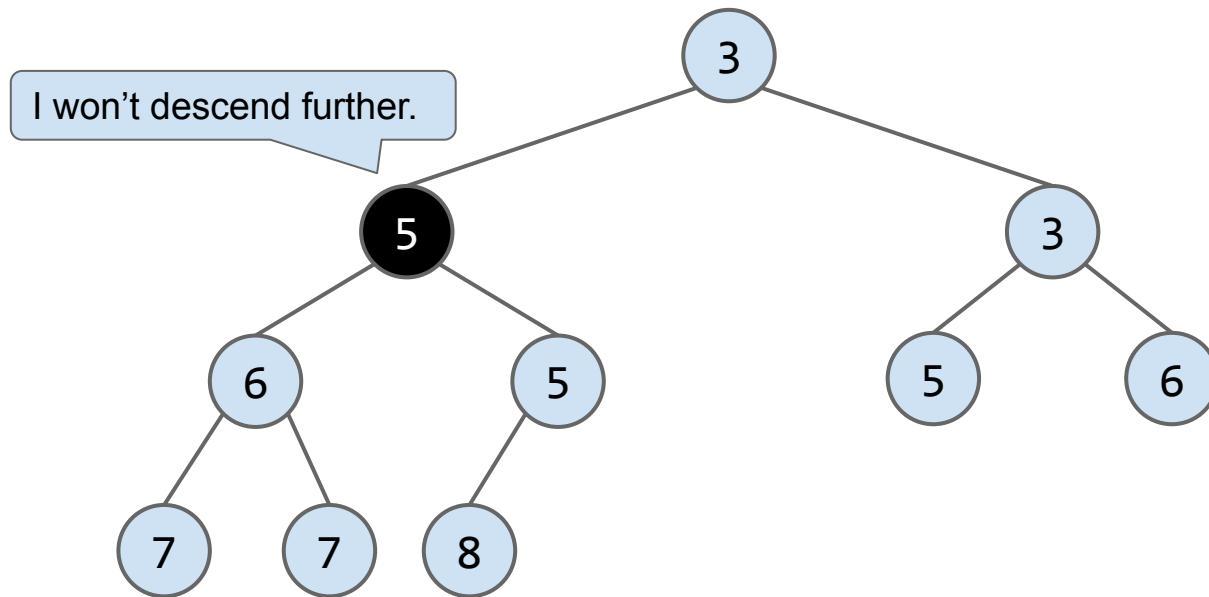
- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.

Break tie arbitrarily.



Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.
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Delete min.

- Swap the last item in the heap into the root.
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Recursive Representation (1)

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- Heap Add
- Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- **Recursive Representation (1)**
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

Data Structures Summary

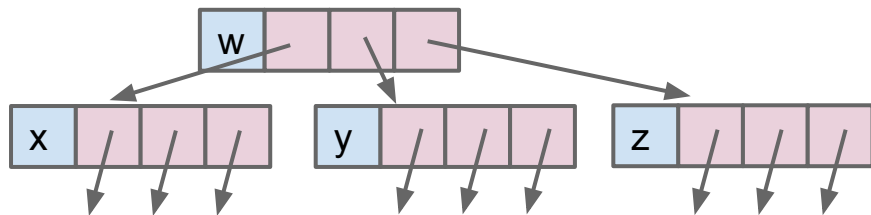
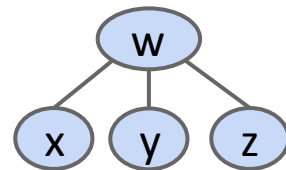
Given a heap, how do we implement PQ operations?

- `getSmallest()` - return the item in the root node.
- `add(x)` - place the new employee in the last position, and promote as high as possible.
- `removeSmallest()` - assassinate the president (of the company), promote the rightmost person in the company to president. Then demote repeatedly, always taking the 'better' successor.

Remaining question: How would we do all this in Java?

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

Approach 1a, 1b and 1c: Create mapping from node to children.



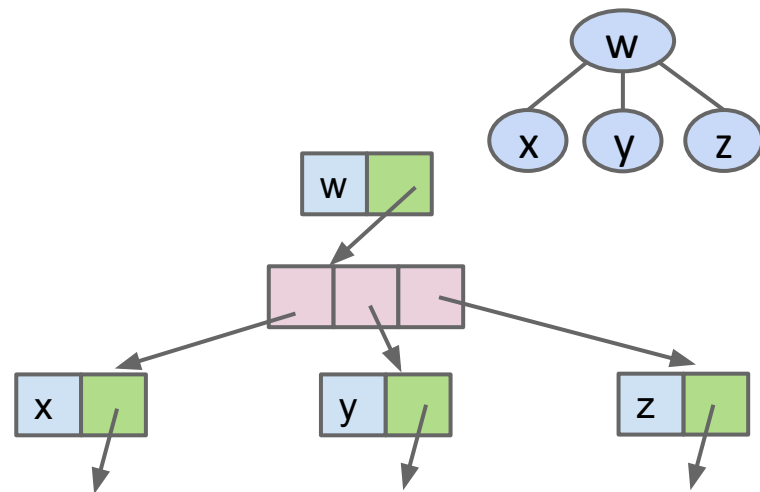
1a: Fixed-Width Nodes (BSTMap used this approach)

```
public class Tree1A<Key> {  
    Key k; // e.g. 0  
    Tree1A left;  
    Tree1A middle;  
    Tree1A right;  
    ...  
}
```

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

Approach 1a, 1b and 1c: Create mapping from node to children.

```
public class Tree1B<Key> {  
    Key k; // e.g.  $\emptyset$   
    Tree1B[] children;  
    ...  
}
```

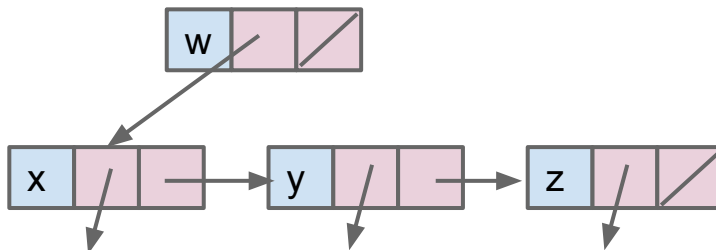
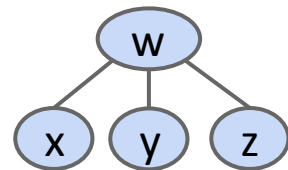


1b: Variable-Width Nodes

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

Approach 1a, 1b and 1c: Create mapping from node to children.

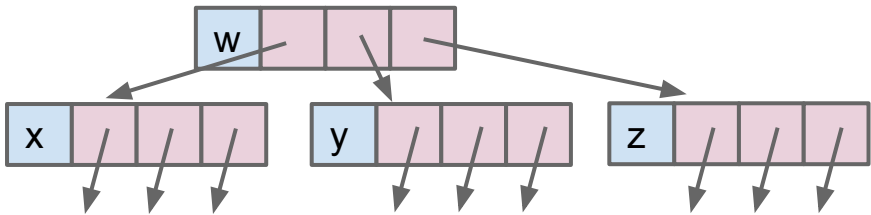
```
public class Tree1C<Key> {  
    Key k; // e.g. 0  
    Tree1C favoredChild;  
    Tree1C sibling;  
    ...  
}
```



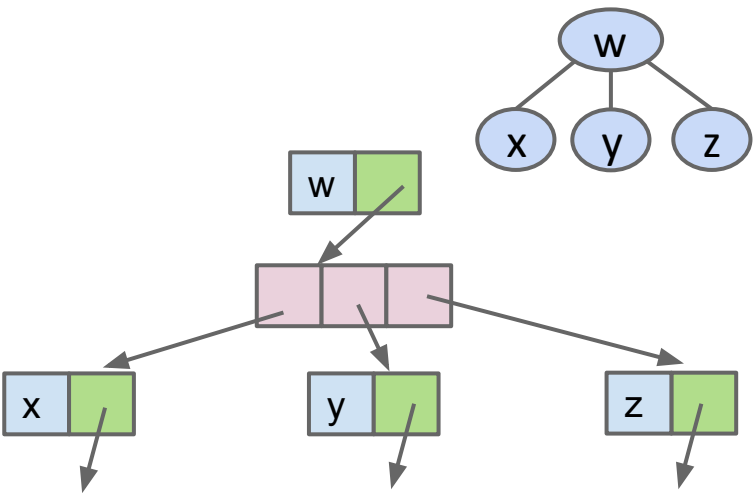
1c: Sibling Tree

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

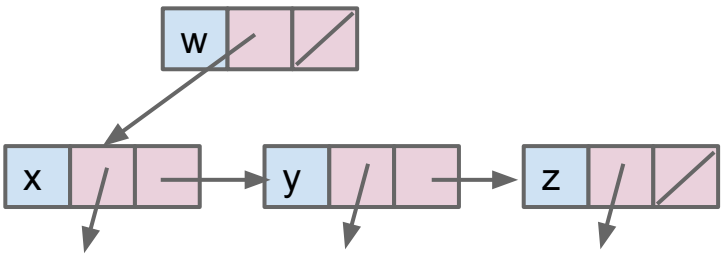
Approach 1a, 1b and 1c: Create mapping from node to children.



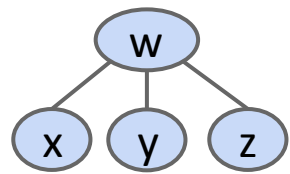
1a: Fixed-Width Nodes



1b: Variable-Width Nodes



1c: Sibling Tree



Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

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- **Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)**

Priority Queue Summary

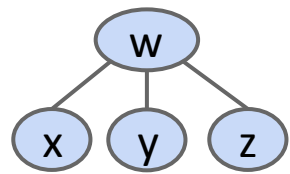
Data Structures Summary

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

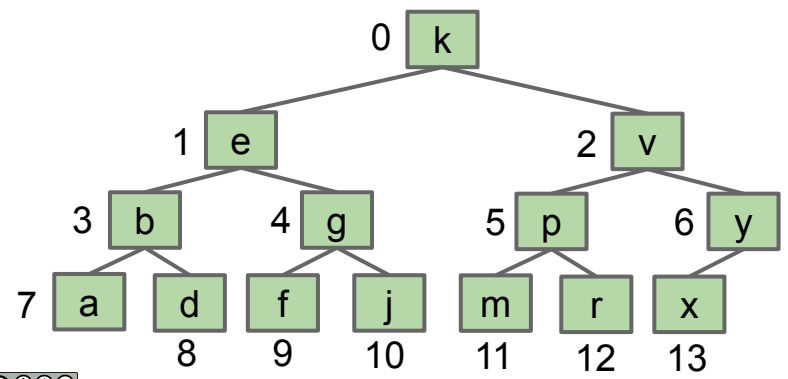
Approach 2: Store keys in an array. Store parentIDs in an array.

- Similar to what we did with disjointSets.

```
public class Tree2<Key> {  
    Key[] keys;  
    int[] parents;  
    ...  
}
```



Key[] keys	w	x	y	z
int[] parents	0	0	0	0
	0	1	2	3



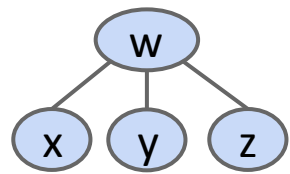
Key[] keys	k	e	v	b	g	p	y	a	d	f	j	m	r	x
	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
int[] parents	0	0	0	1	1	2	2	3	3	4	4	5	5	6
	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13

How do we Represent a Tree in Java?

Approach 3: Store keys in an array. Don't store structure anywhere.

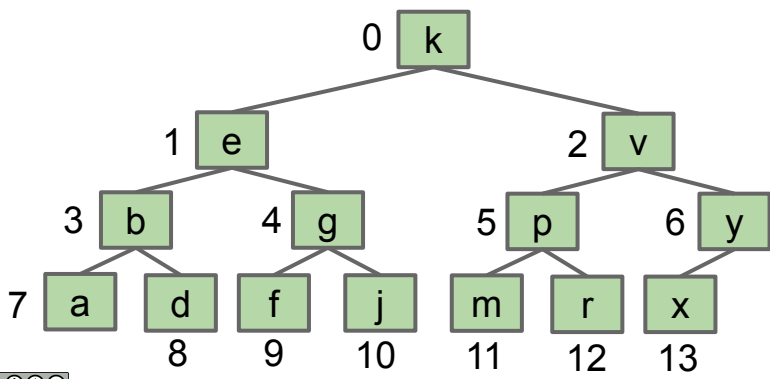
- To interpret array: Simply assume tree is complete.
- Obviously only works for “complete” trees.

```
public class Tree3<Key> {  
    Key[] keys;  
    ...  
}
```



Key[] keys

w	x	y	z
0	1	2	3



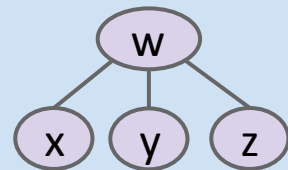
Key[] keys

k	e	v	b	g	p	y	a	d	f	j	m	r	x
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13

A Deep Look at Approach 3

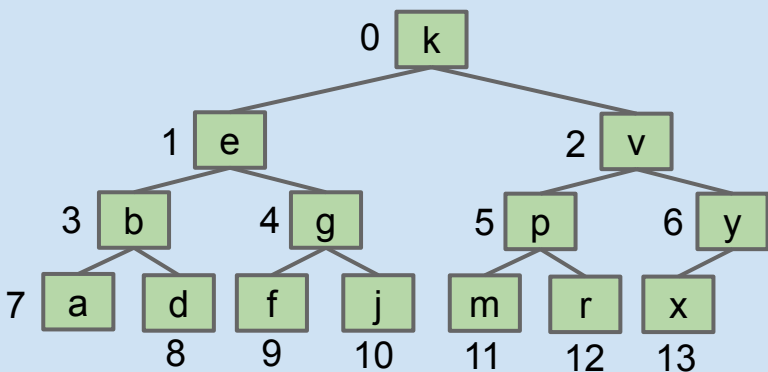
Challenge: Write the `parent(k)` method for approach 3.

```
public void swim(int k) {  
    if (keys[parent(k)] > keys[k]) {  
        swap(k, parent(k));  
        swim(parent(k));  
    }  
}
```



Key[] keys

w	x	y	z
0	1	2	3



Key[] keys

k	e	v	b	g	p	y	a	d	f	j	m	r	x
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13

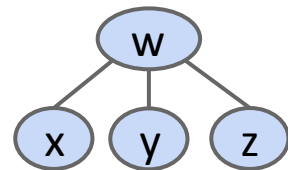
```
public class Tree3<Key> {  
    Key[] keys;  
    ...  
}
```


A Deep Look at Approach 3

Challenge: Write the `parent(k)` method for approach 3.

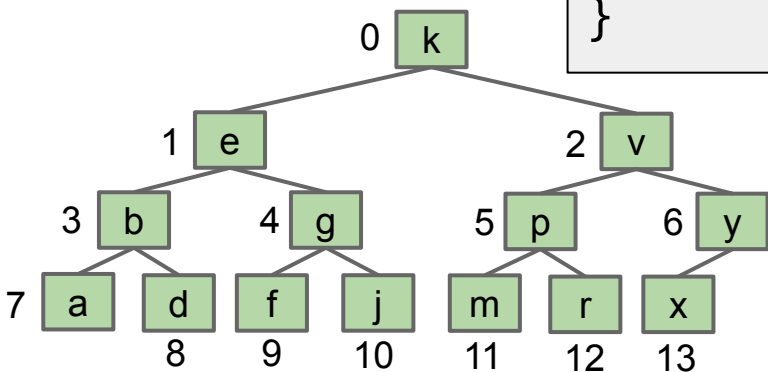
```
public void swim(int k) {  
    if (keys[parent(k)] > keys[k]) {  
        swap(k, parent(k));  
        swim(parent(k));  
    }  
}
```

```
public int parent(int k) {  
    return (k - 1) / 2;  
}
```



Key[] keys

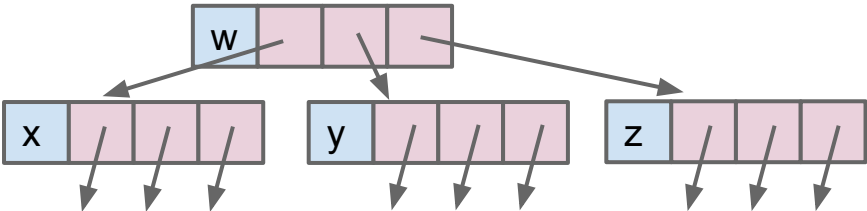
w	x	y	z
0	1	2	3



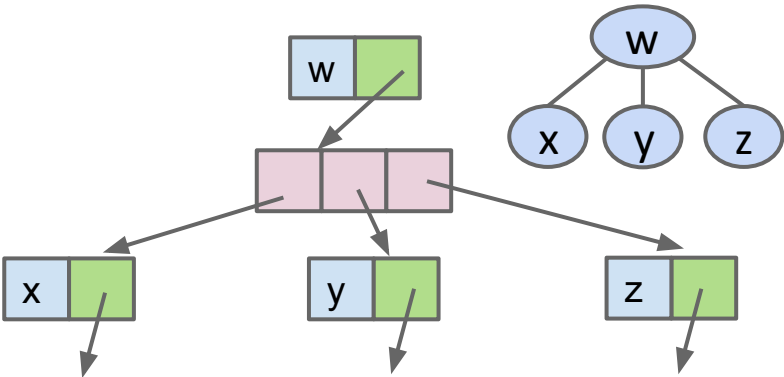
k	e	v	b	g	p	y	a	d	f	j	m	r	x
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13

```
public class Tree3<Key> {  
    Key[] keys;  
    ...  
}
```

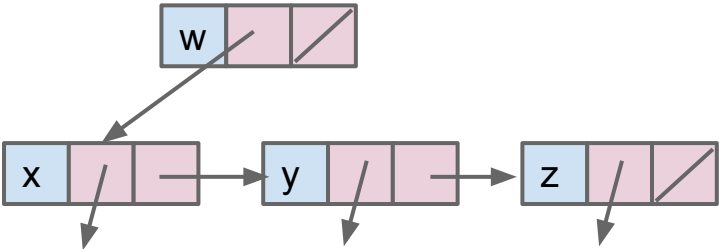
Tree Representations (Summary)



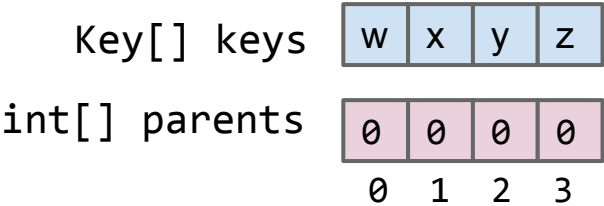
1a: Fixed Number of Links (One Per Child)



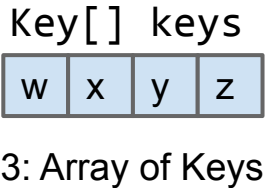
1b: Array of Child Links



1c: FirstBorn/Sibling Links



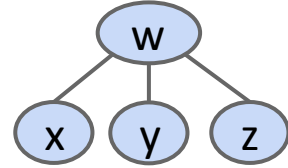
2: Array of Keys, Array of Structure



Approach 3B (book implementation): Leaving One Empty Spot

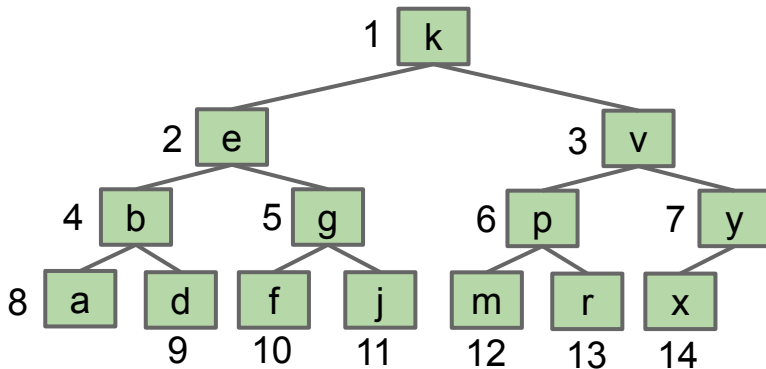
Approach 3b: Store keys in an array. Offset everything by 1 spot.

- Same as 3, but leave spot 0 empty.
- Makes computation of children/parents “nicer”.
 - $\text{leftChild}(k) = k * 2$
 - $\text{rightChild}(k) = k * 2 + 1$
 - $\text{parent}(k) = k / 2$



Key[] keys

-	w	x	y	z
0	1	2	3	4



Key[] keys

-	k	e	v	b	g	p	y	a	d	f	j	m	r	x
0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14

Priority Queue Summary

Lecture 20, CS61B, Spring 2026

Priority Queue Introduction

- Introducing the Priority Queue
- Using a PQ
- Some Bad Implementations

Heaps

- Heap Definitions
- Heap Add
- Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Priority Queue Summary

Data Structures Summary

Heap Implementation of a Priority Queue

	Ordered Array	Bushy BST	Hash Table	Heap
add	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(1)$	$\Theta(\log N)$
getSmallest	$\Theta(1)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(1)$
removeSmallest	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$	$\Theta(N)$	$\Theta(\log N)$

Notes:

Items with same priority hard to handle.

- Why “priority queue”? Can think of position in tree as its “priority.”
- Heap is $\log N$ time AMORTIZED (some resizes, but no big deal).
- BST can have constant getSmallest if you keep a pointer to smallest.
- Heaps handle duplicate priorities much more naturally than BSTs.
- Array based heaps take less memory (very roughly about 1/3rd the memory of representing a tree with approach 1a).

Heap Implementation of a Priority Queue

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Some Implementation Questions

1. How does a PQ know how to determine which item in a PQ is larger?
 - a. What could we change so that there is a default comparison?
2. What constructors are needed to allow for different orderings?

```
/** (Min) Priority Queue: Allowing tracking and removal of the  
 * smallest item in a priority queue. */  
public interface MinPQ<Item> {  
    /** Adds the item to the priority queue. */  
    public void add(Item x);  
    /** Returns the smallest item in the priority queue. */  
    public Item getSmallest();  
    /** Removes the smallest item from the priority queue. */  
    public Item removeSmallest();  
    /** Returns the size of the priority queue. */  
    public int size();  
}
```

Data Structures Summary

Lecture 20, CS61B, Spring 2026

Priority Queue Introduction

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- Heap Definitions
- Heap Add
- Heap Delete

Tree Representations

- Recursive Representation (1)
- Array Representations (2, 3, 3b)

Data Structures Summary

Given a stream of data, retrieve information of interest.

- Examples:
 - Website users post to personal page. Serve content only to friends.
 - Given logs for thousands of weather stations, display weather map for specified date and time.

My Friends: (98) [Edit Friends]

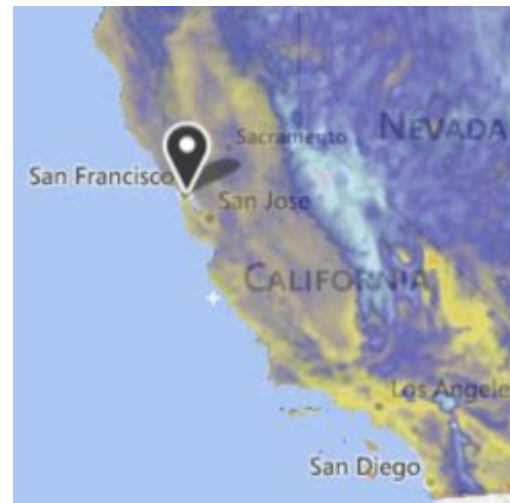
<u>Stephanie</u> 	<u>Hank</u> 	<u>Nikki</u> 	<u>Di</u> 	<u>Claire</u> 	<u>Johnny</u> 
<u>Kate</u> 	<u>Sujit</u> 	<u>Alain</u> 	<u>Dan</u> 	<u>Katharine</u> 	<u>Larry</u> 

[See My 98 Friends]

Waiting for confirmation from 3 friends
[Review/Cancel]

Recent Bulletin Board Posts from your Friends:

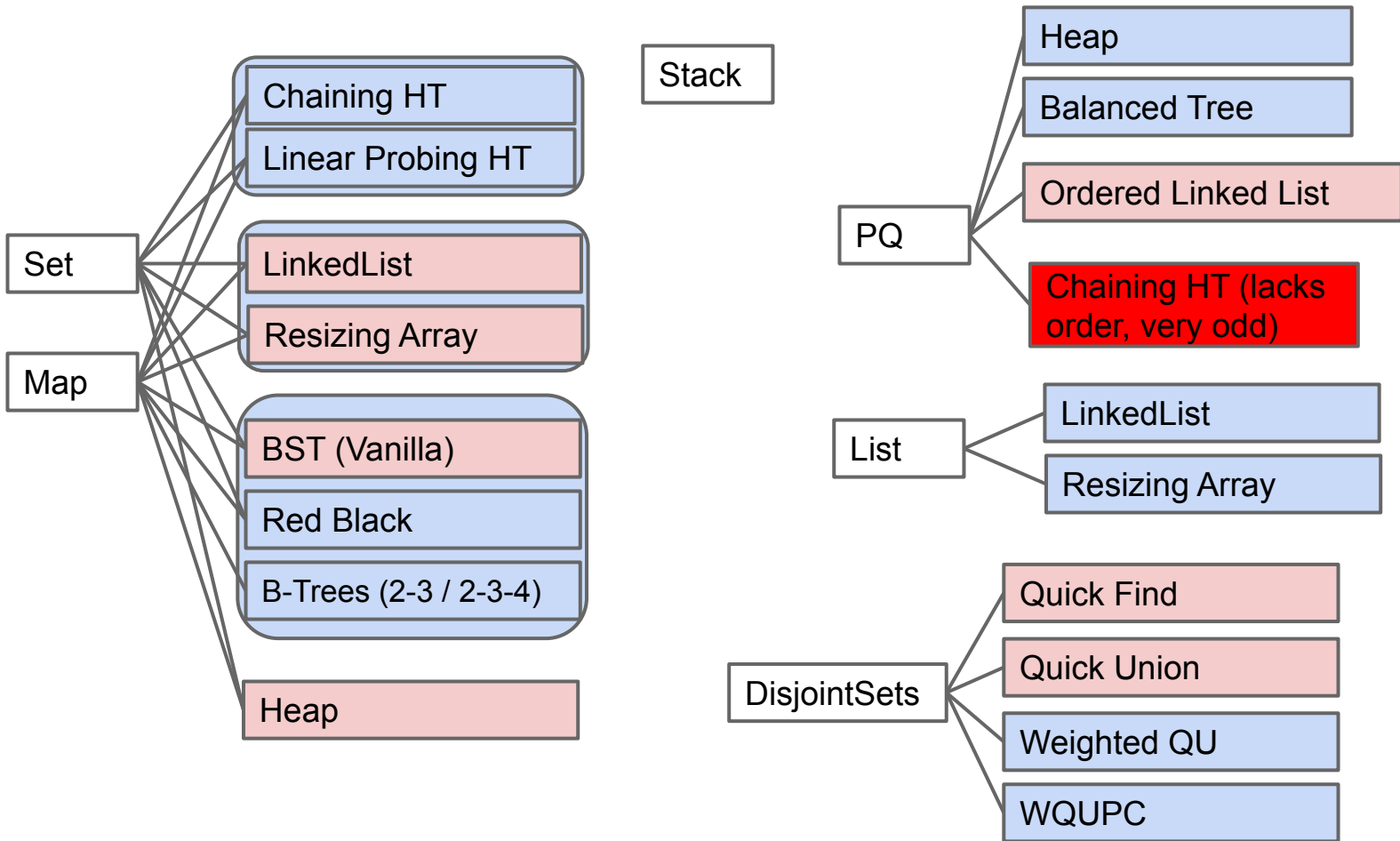
From	Date	Subject
<u>Jojo</u>	10/12/2004	<u>Adam Arcuragi wants you to make out with somebody!</u>
<u>Maria</u>	10/11/2004	<u>anyone looking for loft in greepoint?</u>
<u>Larry</u>	10/09/2004	<u>My new band's debut - 10/16</u>
<u>Jojo</u>	10/09/2004	<u>me and bitter, bitter weeks</u>



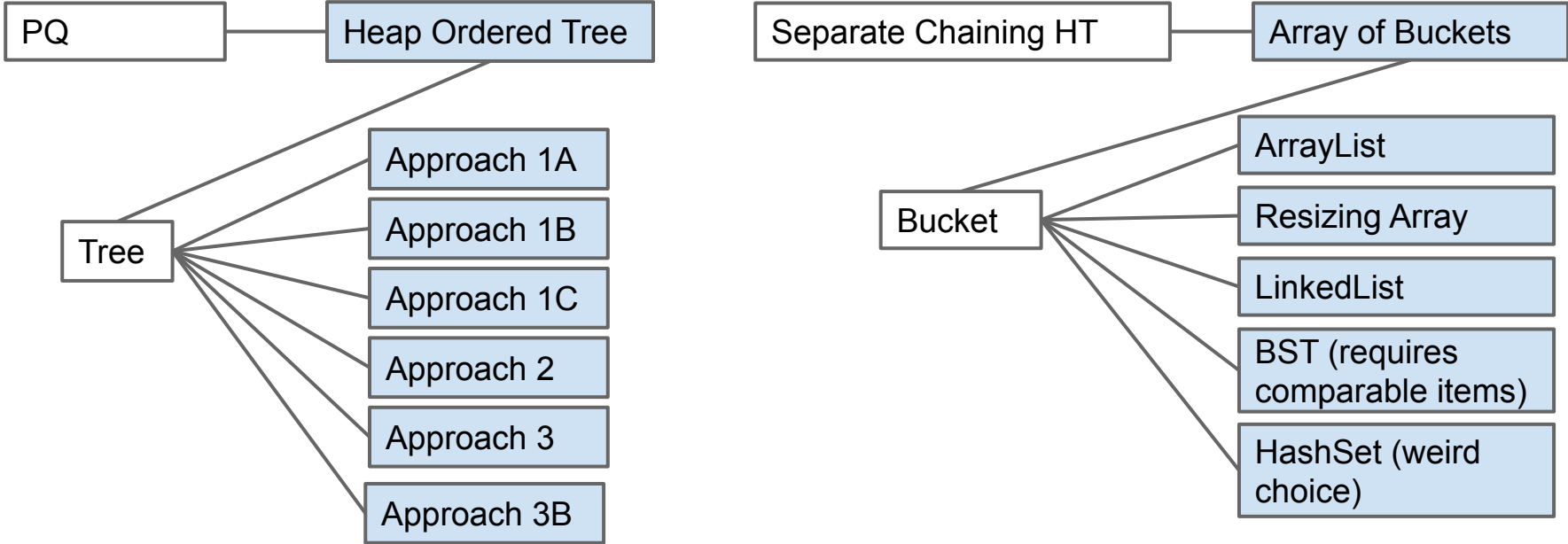
Search Data Structures (The particularly abstract ones)

Name	Storage Operation(s)	Primary Retrieval Operation	Retrieve By:
List	<code>add(key)</code> <code>insert(key, index)</code>	<code>get(index)</code>	index
Map	<code>put(key, value)</code>	<code>get(key)</code>	key identity
Set	<code>add(key)</code>	<code>containsKey(key)</code>	key identity
PQ	<code>add(key)</code>	<code>getSmallest()</code>	key order (a.k.a. key size)
Disjoint Sets	<code>connect(int1, int2)</code>	<code>isConnected(int1, int2)</code>	two int values

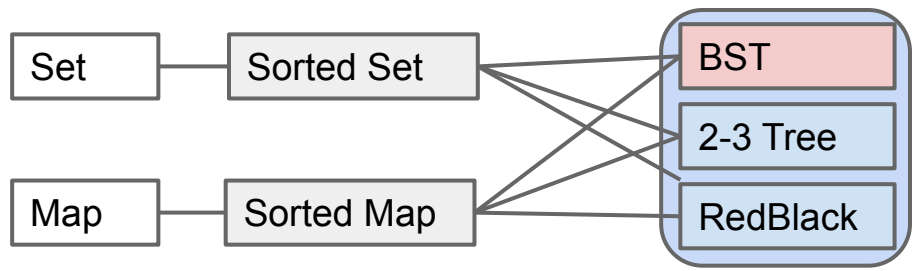
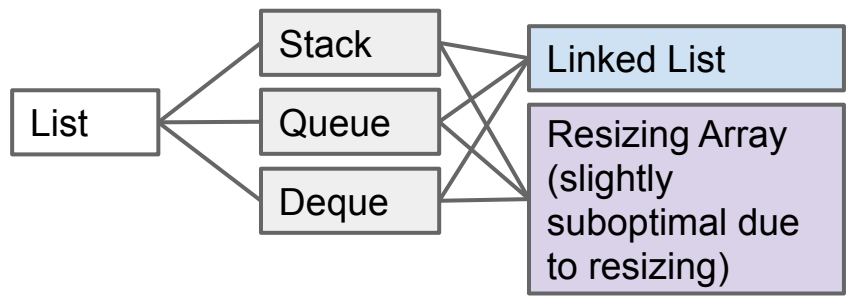
Diagram of Data Structures and ADTs (past semester version)



Abstraction often happens in layers!



Specialized Searching Data Structures:



In Java:
java.util.SortedSet

java.util.SortedMap

PQ

Don't usually consider MinPQ and MaxPQ to be different data structures, since we can just provide the opposite comparator.

Data Structure: A particular way of organizing data.

- We've covered many of the most fundamental abstract data types, their common implementations, and the tradeoffs thereof.
- We'll do two more in this class:
 - Tries, graphs.

V · T · E	Data structures	[hide]
Types	Collection · Container	
Abstract	Associative array · Double-ended priority queue · Double-ended queue · List · Map · Multimap · Priority queue · Queue · Set (multiset) · Disjoint Sets · Stack	
Arrays	Bit array · Circular buffer · Dynamic array · Hash table · Hashed array tree · Sparse array	
Linked	Association list · Linked list · Skip list · Unrolled linked list · XOR linked list	
Trees	B-tree · Binary search tree (AA · AVL · red-black · self-balancing · splay) · Heap (binary · binomial · Fibonacci) · R-tree (R* · R+ · Hilbert) · Trie (Hash tree)	
Graphs	Binary decision diagram · Directed acyclic graph · Directed acyclic word graph	